

WORLD CLASS

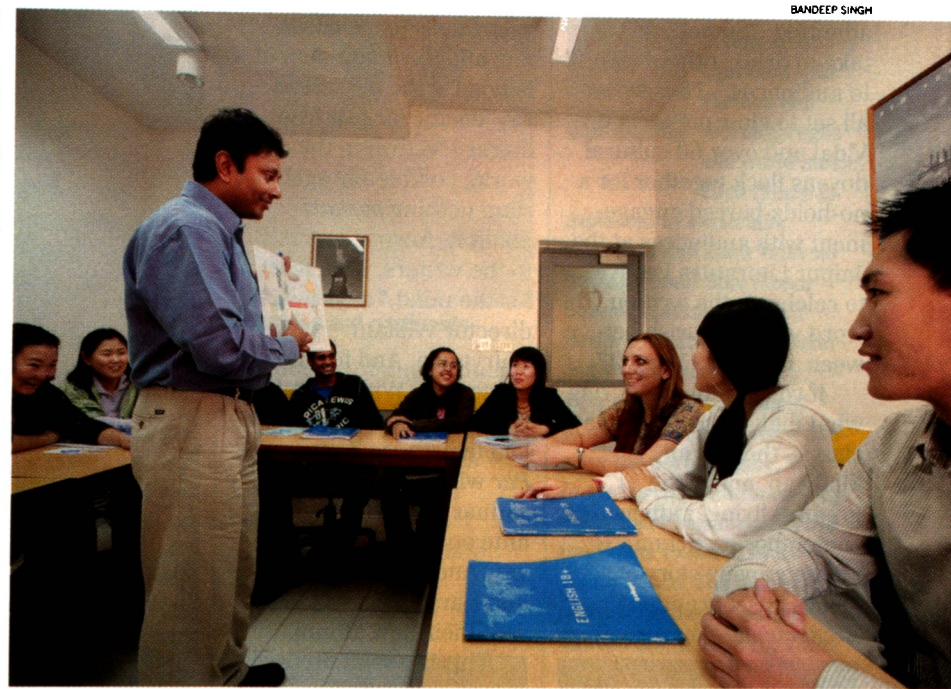
With English fast becoming a global language, more and more foreigners are flocking to India to take lessons of a different kind, for a lower price

At the Inlingua School of English Language in Delhi's crowded South Extension area, classes are under-way. In Tokyo Room, which has nothing to do with Tokyo or with the students sitting here, teacher Rakesh Dheer, a retired army officer, converses with his students. "What happens when you drink too much beer?" he asks. "You get becoming fat", comes a reply. "When you are tired, you...?" "Eat!" replies 20-year-old Obada, a Palestinian. Today's lesson is about interpreting situations. They have 10 minutes to fill in their worksheets, but 17-year-old Nguyen Thu Trang from Vietnam, finishes hers in five minutes. In a class of eight, half are foreigners, including an Afghan and an Iranian.

In the adjacent Rome Room, Amar Gujral, too, is teaching a diverse group of Koreans, Indians and students from Congo. In 2007, more than 25 per cent of the registrations at Inlingua were those of foreign students. They flock from countries like Afghanistan, Iran, South Korea, Vietnam, Japan, Mongolia and Palestine. While a majority choose India over their native countries due to the quality of teaching, it's the cost factor that attracts the rest. Obada, who plans to study business administration, claims English courses aren't as good back home. "When I came to India, I couldn't speak English. And today, I have bought a mobile phone all by myself," he boasts.

Many students, from countries like Sudan, South Africa, Japan and China, come to pursue degree courses. Some aspire to join BPOs, while others wish to work in the US or the UK. A basic language course in India starts at Rs 3,000, whereas, it is no less than Rs 14,000 in the US. A similar one-year course at the School of Oriental and African Studies in London costs around £12,000 (Rs 1 lakh).

Nguyen heard of these courses from a cousin who toured India and



BANDEEP SINGH

suggested she study here. She can now comprehend and write, but cannot speak the language yet. At Rs 7,500 a level (and there are six levels), she says India is still cheaper than Vietnam, which costs 15 to 20 per cent more.

English being the universal language of commerce and technology, demand for such schools is increasing by the day and the supply side has responded with equal gusto. While most of them target both Indian and foreign students, some like Mysore's Jagadguru Sri Shivarathreeshwara Centre for Language Training entertain only foreigners. No one knows exactly how big this market is, but school-chains are expanding to accommodate more students. Inlingua began in 2002 with only 20 students, and now has seven branches in the city to its credit. Similarly, 10 per cent of the total population of Pune-based Miracle 20-20 Vision Educational comprises foreign students. Says Priya Malhotra, director, "this trend actually started in 2005. I had just seven students then. By

COMMON PURSUIT: Students at an English class in Delhi

2006-07, I had trained more than 150 students." Talking of the cost differential she says, "I used to pay \$350 (Rs 14,000) for an accent course in the US, for which I charge Rs 3,000."

Knowledge of English as a language is not only necessary for top executives, but for everyone in the corporate food chain, as companies are globalising. MNCs like Samsung routinely send their Korean executives, posted in India, to learn English. According to Gujral, at least six to eight Koreans come from Samsung, annually. "They don't want business communication courses, but a cultural experience", says Gujral.

In jobs ranging from offices to factory floors, recruiters say English-speakers are in demand. The ambitious lot is aiming for higher-level jobs and international postings. Whatever be their native language, everybody will eventually have to be bi-lingual.

by Nandini Vaish with Renu Ojha

"The trend began in 2005. I had seven students then, 150 now."

PRIYA MALHOTRA, DIRECTOR, MIRACLE 20-20 VISION EDUCATIONAL